



How We Tested

The test bed used to test the OCR software was a Pentium III 500 MHz, with 128 MB RAM, running Windows XP and a UMAX PowerLook II scanner. All the documents were scanned at 24-bit colour depth and at 300 dpi—anything above 300 dpi makes no difference to the OCR software. The software were tested with their default settings, and the results were stored in Microsoft Word and Excel formats.

We evaluated the software on the following parameters:

Performance: OCR software is used in an environment where different types of documents have to be recognised, ranging from common Word documents to newspaper clippings, Excel tables and so on. Hence, we prepared a range of documents and checked the output for the level of accuracy in reproducing the original and the level of formatting retained. The following types of document were scanned and used in the test process: among the simpler ones were an Inkjet printout, a photocopy, a fax document, a dot-matrix printout and a typewrit-

ten document; and among the complex ones—an Excel sheet, a newspaper clip, a magazine page with reverse fonts, and a document with several different symbols. The documents had different weightages in our tests because, for example, one scans Inkjet documents more often than Excel sheets.

The inkjet printout was a generic Word document with all the possible formatting—bold, italics, indents, different font types and sizes—thrown in. The photocopy, fax document and the dot-matrix printouts were simple documents produced using their respective machines—these documents were used because they are still prevalent in Indian offices. The Excel page was a printout of an Excel sheet with frills such as coloured cells, graphs and vertical text. The newspaper clip had pictures and several columns. A magazine page with reverse fonts, i.e., a black background with white and yellow fonts, was used. The document with symbols had all the common symbols such as '@' and '&', and accented letters such as 'é'.

Features: OCR software should have features that minimise the need for manual intervention during the conversion process. It should have features such as support for importing images directly from a scanner. It should also support a variety of file formats, for both input and output. A learning mode that allows the software to learn from the corrections you make is an added advantage. Features such as batch processing would allow easy processing of multiple documents. The scanned images might not have a proper orientation, and the software should be able to correct such human errors. We gave weightages to features based on their importance.

Ease of use: We looked at the user-friendliness of the interface. Apart from having self-explanatory icons, the relevant ones should be easily accessible. The presence of a wizard that takes the user through the entire task—right from importing images to recognising the text and exporting them—is a must. We looked at how good the help and documentation was, along with the online help.

it an image to work with. Also, right-click on an image and the option to recognise it using Cuneiform shows up.

At \$69 (Rs 3,300), Cuneiform is a good solution for the non-demanding user who needs to OCR simple documents.

- + Inexpensive, reasonably accurate
- Gets thrown off by images and multiple fonts

OmniPage Pro 12

Makes life simple

OmniPage is one of the heavyweights—it's full-featured and tremendously accurate. One of its most useful features is its ability to accurately convert PDF documents—just enter a PDF filename, and the software spits out a Microsoft Word document, with all the fonts and tables retained! You hardly need to bother double-checking the output; you can always assume the job has been done perfectly. Text gets auto-selected—you don't need to specify where on the image the text is, though you can do this for complex documents. The image also gets de-skewed automatically, in case the page got tilted when you scanned it.

The interface is impeccable, and there's a wizard that makes it easy for a 10-year-



OmniPage has an attractive interface, and all the tools you'll ever need

old to OCR a document. It guides you through the entire three-step process—importing a document into the software, OCRing it and saving it as a file. You do have options, but if you're new to this and don't want to experiment, just keep clicking OK and you're done. Advanced users can manually specify the layout of the document, so that OmniPage doesn't get confused by graphics and the like. After OCRing, you can send your document directly as e-mail, with a single click, or save it in the .doc, .rtf and .txt file formats.

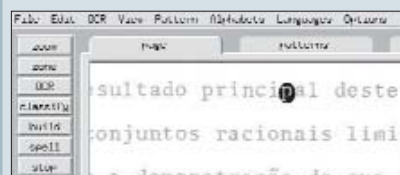
The OCR Proofreader appears immediately after OCRing. The intelli-train feature takes input from the corrections you make during proofing—and the program remem-

bers the character shape and the changed solution for this shape, and searches other similar character shapes in the document. Also included is a user dictionary, similar

Linux OCR

Vividata's OCR shop is a package that uses ScanSoft's OmniPage engine, which previously was used only on the Mac and PC platforms. The company Web site says that the software uses advanced technologies such as expert systems and neural systems. It is available in two versions—a desktop version and a server version. Visit <http://www.vividata.com/ocrshop.html> for further details.

Clara OCR (Co-operative Lightweight chAracter Recognizer) is another OCR package for Linux that sports a good GUI. After two years of development, it is now in the beta stage. You can download the software from <http://www.claraocr.org>.



Yes, Linux has OCR software. Try Clara